🪖 World War I: Reading

US History · Unit 7 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with causes of WWI, Should the US get involved?, Shell Shock video, propaganda posters, Treaty of Versailles notes

Name: _____

The Great War

By 1914 Europe was a powder keg. Nations built huge armies and navies (militarism), signed alliances promising to defend each other, competed for colonies (imperialism) and felt intense national pride (nationalism). Historians remember these long-term causes as MAIN. The spark came on June 28, 1914, when a Serbian nationalist assassinated Archduke Franz Ferdinand of Austria-Hungary. Within weeks the alliance system dragged the Allies (France, Britain and Russia) and the Central Powers (Germany, Austria-Hungary and the Ottoman Empire) into war.

President Woodrow Wilson declared the US neutral, and many Americans wanted to stay out. But German U-boats attacked ships near Britain. In 1915 the British liner Lusitania sank, killing 1,198 people including 128 Americans. In early 1917 Germany resumed unrestricted submarine warfare, and British spies decoded the Zimmermann Note, in which Germany offered Mexico the return of Texas, New Mexico and Arizona if it attacked the US. In April 1917 Congress declared war.

On the Western Front, soldiers lived in muddy, rat-filled trenches separated by “no man's land.” New weapons such as machine guns, poison gas, tanks and airplanes made the war deadlier than any before. Many survivors suffered shell shock, which we now call post-traumatic stress disorder. Black Americans served in segregated units; the Harlem Hellfighters earned French medals, and Eugene Bullard flew for France because the US would not accept Black pilots.

At home, the Committee on Public Information (CPI) produced propaganda posters urging Americans to enlist, buy Liberty Bonds and save food with “Meatless Mondays.” Women took factory jobs and served as nurses. The Espionage and Sedition Acts made it a crime to criticize the war; socialist Eugene Debs went to prison for an anti-war speech. German Americans faced suspicion and harassment. In 1918 a flu pandemic killed millions worldwide.

The armistice ended the fighting at 11 a.m. on November 11, 1918. Wilson's Fourteen Points called for a fair peace and a League of Nations to prevent future wars. But the Treaty of Versailles (1919) forced Germany to accept blame, give up land and pay huge reparations. New nations such as Poland and Czechoslovakia appeared on the map. The US Senate rejected the treaty and never joined the League.

Check your reading

1. Explain the four MAIN causes of WWI.

2. Give two reasons the US entered the war in 1917.

3. How did the Sedition Act limit freedom at home?